III—The Veil

> ‘It was the effect of the grace of God that I found no capable minister, otherwise people would have considered my measures had been devised by him.’
>
> – Akbar, Happy Sayings, *Ain-i-Akbari*

Akbar was not in Delhi when his father died. He was with Bairam Khan, chasing Sikandar Suri, who had retreated to the great fortress of Mankot, far west of Sirhind, near the Chenab. He had been in battle camps for over a year, but it is unlikely that he was fatigued, or craving a return to the relative comforts of Kabul or – God forbid! – the classroom. Until his father died, in fact, Akbar’s Hindustani adventure had been going rather well. It wasn’t all battles and marches, first of all. A painting from this time shows Akbar on a horse, stirrups adjusted for his height, wearing yellow pyjamas and a red shirt, a jaunty feather in his turban, out for a day’s hawking in Punjab with Bairam Khan.[1] One can imagine the thrills of discovering new animals, new vistas, new hunts, for a boy of his temperament. It was here, in Punjab, that Akbar discovered the two animals he most adored through his life. Bairam’s brother-in-law, Wali Beg, gave the prince his first cheetah, along with its keeper, Dundu. Dundu would become a royal huntsman under Akbar, and the sight of trained cheetahs, streaks of lightning striking prey, would never cease to delight his master. But even cheetahs might be forgotten in the face of elephants.

Elephants! Abul Fazl tells us their names: the one Akbar first rode – Dalsingar; the one Akbar first rode without a keeper – Faujbidar; the one Akbar first rode while it was musth – Damudar; the one Akbar first rode while it was musth *into* a fight with another – Jhalpa. All in a matter of two years, between the ages of twelve and fourteen, and each one, it is clear, etched in Akbar’s memory; who else, after all, would have recited the names of these long-ago beasts when Abul Fazl began to write his history?[2]

Elephants were the joy of Akbar’s life – he collected them like stamps, he mastered them like rhyme, he coveted them like gold. By contrast, his father, having spent years in Hindustan, had never learnt – as was clear in Kannauj – to drive these animals. Akbar was riding musth elephants in two years: astride their necks, adrenalin aflow as the animals bellowed, making